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2 Samuel

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2 Samuel

A. Theme and Background.

1. As was mentioned in the background for first Samuel, both first and second Samuel are one book in the Jewish Bible. They were first separated by the Greek translation of the Old Testament, the Septuagint about 250 BC.
2. Second Samuel continues the narrative of David after the death of King Saul. He is anointed King of Judah at Hebron, where he ruled for seven years and six months and then at Jerusalem, where he reigned over all of Judah and Israel for thirty-three years (vs. 5:5).
3. David is representative, although imperfect, of what theocratic rule will be under Christ upon His return. David kept the Lord's commands all his life except in the case of Uriah the Hittite (1 Kings 15:5) which is recorded in chapter eleven.

B. Chapters one through four.

1. Chapter One. David learns of Saul's death by means of a young man, an Amalekite, who claimed he ended Saul's life as a mercy killing at Saul's request. He brought his crown and armlet. David is anguished and has him killed, as he had claimed to kill God's anointed. The rest of the chapter is David's lamentation over Saul and Jonathan.
2. Chapter Two records that David is anointed King over Judah and Saul's son, Ish-Bosheth is made King of Israel by Abner, commander of Saul's army. Abner's men and Joab's men battle each other.
3. Chapter Three. There was a long war between the house of Saul and the house of David. David's house grew stronger while Saul's house grew weaker (vs. 3:1). Ish-Bosheth angers Abner over the accusation that Abner slept with one of Saul's concubines. Abner sends messengers to David seeking consolidation of the kingdom. David agrees on condition that his wife, Saul's daughter Michal, who was given to another man be returned to him. Joab murders Abner and David mourns his death.
4. Chapter Four. Jonathan, Saul's son, had a son crippled in both feet as a result of falling when his nurse fled in haste at the news of Saul's and Jonathan's death (vs. 4:4). Ish-Bosheth is murdered while he was taking a noon day rest by two men who were captains of his raiding parties (vs. 4:5-6). They took Ish-Bosheth's

head to David seeking reward for killing him. David has them killed for murdering a righteous man on his bed (vs. 4:12).

C. Chapter Five. David is anointed King over Israel thereby consolidating the united kingdom. David seizes Jerusalem and becomes greater and greater because the Lord was with him (vs. 5:10). Hiram, King of Tyre, sends building material and craftsmen who build David a house. After inquiring of the Lord, David defeats an army of the Philistines (vs. 5:19). An intriguing but small note is made in verse 5:21, where it says that David's men carried off the idols of the Philistines who left them after the battle. This again shows how Israel still clung to idols.

D. Chapter Six.

1. David brings the Ark on a new cart from where it had been at Baale-judah. The Oxen stumble and Uzzah reaches out with his hand to steady it. "And the anger of the LORD was kindled against Uzzah, and God struck him down there because of his error, and he died there beside the ark of God" (vs. 6:7).
2. David then fears the Lord, and the Ark is placed in the home of Obed-edom for three months. When David learns that the Lord blessed Obed-edom and his household, he brings it up to the tent prepared for it.
3. As he brings it into the city of David, he leaps and dances with joy and inadvertently exposes himself. Michal sees him and rebukes him. The chapter concludes that she had no child until her death.

E. Chapter Seven. The prophet Nathan affirms the covenant with David that his house and his throne will be established forever (vs. 7:16-17). The chapter closes with David's prayer of gratitude.

F. Chapter Eight records David's victories and his officials.

G. Chapter Nine. David shows great kindness to Mephibosheth, the sole surviving son of Jonathan. He decrees that Mephibosheth will eat at his table.

H. Chapter Ten records David's victories over the Ammonites and the Syrians.

I. Chapter Eleven is the sordid story of David's adultery with Bathsheba and the arrangement for the death of her husband.

1. The Bible records that it was Spring when kings go out to battle, but David remained in Jerusalem (vs. 11:1). That was David's first mistake. Secondly, he

looked upon Bathsheba while she was bathing from his rooftop advantage. He should have looked away immediately but, he lusted for her. Thirdly, he sent for her and laid with her and she became pregnant. He attempts to cover up his sin by sending for Uriah, her husband, in hopes he will have sex with his wife, and the implication would be that he is the father. But Uriah did not, as his fellow soldiers were camping in a field. Uriah was one of David's mighty men (2 Samuel 23:29; 1 Chronicles 11:41), or those who were especially valiant and trustworthy, which makes David's sin even more heinous.

2. David sends him back with instructions to Joab to put him in the forefront of the fighting and then withdraw so that he would be killed. David then takes Bathsheba as his wife and a child is born.

J. Chapter Twelve.

1. Nathan's rebukes of David for his sin by using a parable of a rich man who takes a little lamb of a poor man. David's anger is kindled against the fictitious rich man and says that he deserves to die (vs. 12:5). Nathan proclaims words that pierce to the heart of David: "You are that man!" (vs. 12:7).
2. The Lord then tells David through Nathan "Now therefore the sword shall never depart from your house, because you have despised me and have taken the wife of Uriah the Hittite to be your wife" (vs. 12:10).
3. David repents and Nathan tells him that he will not die, but because he has utterly scorned the Lord, the child born to him will die (vs. 12:14).
4. David prays and fasts in hope that the Lord will be gracious and allow the child live. But the child dies on the seventh day. David gives us a glimpse of eternity when he proclaims: "I shall go to him, but he will not return to me" (vs. 12:23b). The chapter concludes with the birth of Solomon to David and Bathsheba and the taking of the city Rabbah of the Ammonites.

K. Chapter 13 marks the beginning of God's judgement upon David for his sin. One of his sons Amnon, rapes his half-sister Tamar, a sister of another son Absalom. After two years, Absalom murders Amnon and flees to Geshur for three years. But the spirit of David longed to go out to Absalom (vs. 13:39).

L. Chapter 14 records how Joab interceded for Absalom by means of a woman who pretended to have two sons, one of which killed the other setting up a situation similar to David. Absalom returns to Jerusalem but, he does not go into the presence of David for two years. Absalom begins to gain the approval of the people. He is

described as handsome in appearance. He cuts his hair only once a year, which will be his eventual downfall. Joab again intercedes for Absalom and he is reconciled to David.

M. Chapter 15 describes Absalom's conspiracy to seize the throne. David flees Jerusalem.

N. Chapter 16 relates how Ziba, the servant of Mephibosheth met David with provisions. He tells David of Mephibosheth's belief that since David has fled, that Israel will give Mephibosheth the kingdom of his father Saul. Due to Mephibosheth's unfaithfulness for all David has done for him, David gives Ziba all that belonged to Mephibosheth. A man of Saul's house named Shimi curses David from afar. Absalom pitches a tent on the roof of the palace and goes into David's concubines that he had left to care for the palace. This was to make known to the people that he has made himself a stench to David and the hands of those aligned with him would be strengthened (vs. 15:21-22).

O. Chapter 17 describes how Absalom's counselor Ahithophel gave advice for Absalom to pursue David while he was weary from his flight (vs.17:1-4). Initially, the advice seems good to Absalom and the elders of Israel. Absalom calls in a second opinion from Hushai, who disagrees with Ahithophel's advice. He cautions him that David is a man of war and tells him to wait until all Israel is gathered to him. Absalom accepts Hushai's advice "For the LORD had ordained to defeat the good counsel of Ahithophel, so that the LORD might bring harm upon Absalom" (vs. 17:14b). Ahithophel sees that his advice is rejected. He goes back to his home, places his affairs in order and hangs himself (vs. 17:23).

P. Chapter 18 tells of a great battle between Absalom's men of Israel and David's men of Judah. Absalom is riding on a mule and his hair gets entangled in the branches of a tree. Joab and his armor-bears kill him (vs. 18:14-15). David learns and weeps for his son Absalom.

Q. Chapter 19. David returns to Jerusalem and is met by Shimei, who had cursed him. He pleads with David to forgive him of that incident, and David pardons him. Mephibosheth also comes; he has not taken care of his feet or hair since David departed. He tells David that his servant Ziba deceived him by telling him that he was saddling a donkey so that he could go with David. David decides to divide the property of Mephibosheth between Ziba and Mephibosheth, but Mephibosheth says that Ziba can take it all, as he is glad that David has come home safely. The

narrative continues with how Barzilai, an aged man, had provided provisions earlier to David. David invites him to come with him to Jerusalem, but Barzilai declines, as he is old and desires to die and be buried with his parents.

R. Chapter 20 records the rebellion of a man named Sheba, who led the men of Israel away from David. Joab and the army pursue him to a city named Abel. They threw up a siege ramp and were in the process of battering down the wall when a wise woman called out to Joab that they would give up Sheba, so that the city would not be destroyed. Joab agrees, and they throw out the head of Sheba and the city is spared.

S. Chapter 21. There was famine in Israel for three years. David inquires of the Lord and is told that there is bloodguilt on Saul's house. This was because he put the Gibeonites to death who had been promised protection by Joshua. David asks them what should be done. They ask for seven sons of Saul and they are put to death. It should be noted that David did not inquire of the Lord what to do, but took the advice of the Gibeonites. The rest of the chapter records a war with the Philistines where David is victorious over them, including killing more of the descendants of the giants.

T. Chapters 22 and 23 are David's song of deliverance and his last words. Chapter 23 also is a record of David's mighty men.

U. Chapter 24 is the conclusion of 2 Samuel, and describes how the Lord was angry against Israel and incited David to take a census of Israel and Judah (vs. 24:1). Compare this account with the parallel one in 1 Chronicles 21:1 where it says that "Satan rose up against Israel and incited David to take a census of Israel." The Lord gives David three choices of judgement through the prophet Gad. David chooses three days of Pestilence: "I am in great distress. Let us fall into the hand of the LORD, for his mercy is great; but let me not fall into the hand of man" (vs. 24:14). Seventy thousand men die but Jerusalem is spared. The chapter closes with the account of David purchasing from Araunah his threshing floor to erect an altar to the Lord. Araunah offers to give David the property, but David says: "No, but I will buy it from you for a price. I will not offer burnt offerings to the LORD my God that cost me nothing" (vs. 24:24). This threshing floor became the site on which the temple was later built.

V. Discussion Questions, Application and Passing it On.

1. Uzzah was killed by God “for his error” in steadying the cart with the ark on it. The ark was to be moved by means of rods through the rings on the corners of the ark on the shoulders of the priests (Exodus 25:14). David and Uzzah were apparently unaware of this requirement. The ark was holy and was to be treated with the utmost respect as it represented God Himself. Although both David and Uzzah had good intentions regarding the ark, God sent a powerful message in this incident as He is to be treated with awe and respect. Under the new covenant of the blood of Christ, we have the boldness to approach His throne (Hebrews 4:16). Yet, we must not allow this boldness to reduce our awe of a holy God. Have you treated the holiness of God with a lack of respect in the past? Do you see this tendency present in worship music or other aspects of a church service?
2. The story of David and Bathsheba has important lessons for men especially. Some have attempted to place an accusation of entrapment against Bathsheba. But careful reading of the text reveals that David rose from his bed to walk on the roof of the king’s house. Bathsheba could not have known the meaning of this; she was bathing on the rooftop where relief was commonly found from the heat of the day. All blame must be placed upon David as a powerful individual who exercised his lustful will upon the wife of one of his faithful mighty men. What lessons can we learn from David’s sin? Have you fallen into sin in the past by being somewhere where you shouldn’t? Have you attempted to hide your sin by covering it up? David experienced God’s justice and discipline from this incident. Have you had the experience of receiving God’s justice and discipline over your sin?
3. David accepts the request of the Gibeonites regarding how to end the famine (chapter 21). He did not consult the Lord. Have you ever taken the advice of others in a matter instead of consulting the Lord?
4. David refused the offer of a gift of the threshing floor of Araunah as “I will not offer burnt offerings to the LORD my God that cost me nothing”. How do you think your offerings to the Lord are viewed by Him? Do your offerings cost you nothing?

This Old Testament survey was provided by Joshua Nations (JoshuaNations.org)

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In Christ,

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